

Puhar was still dark.



The festival was already being built.

**CHAPTER ONE · THE FESTIVAL
PROCLAMATION**

Old sand was cleared from the public ways.



Lift.

Again.



Will all of Puhar look different by sunrise?

Look again when the drum sounds.

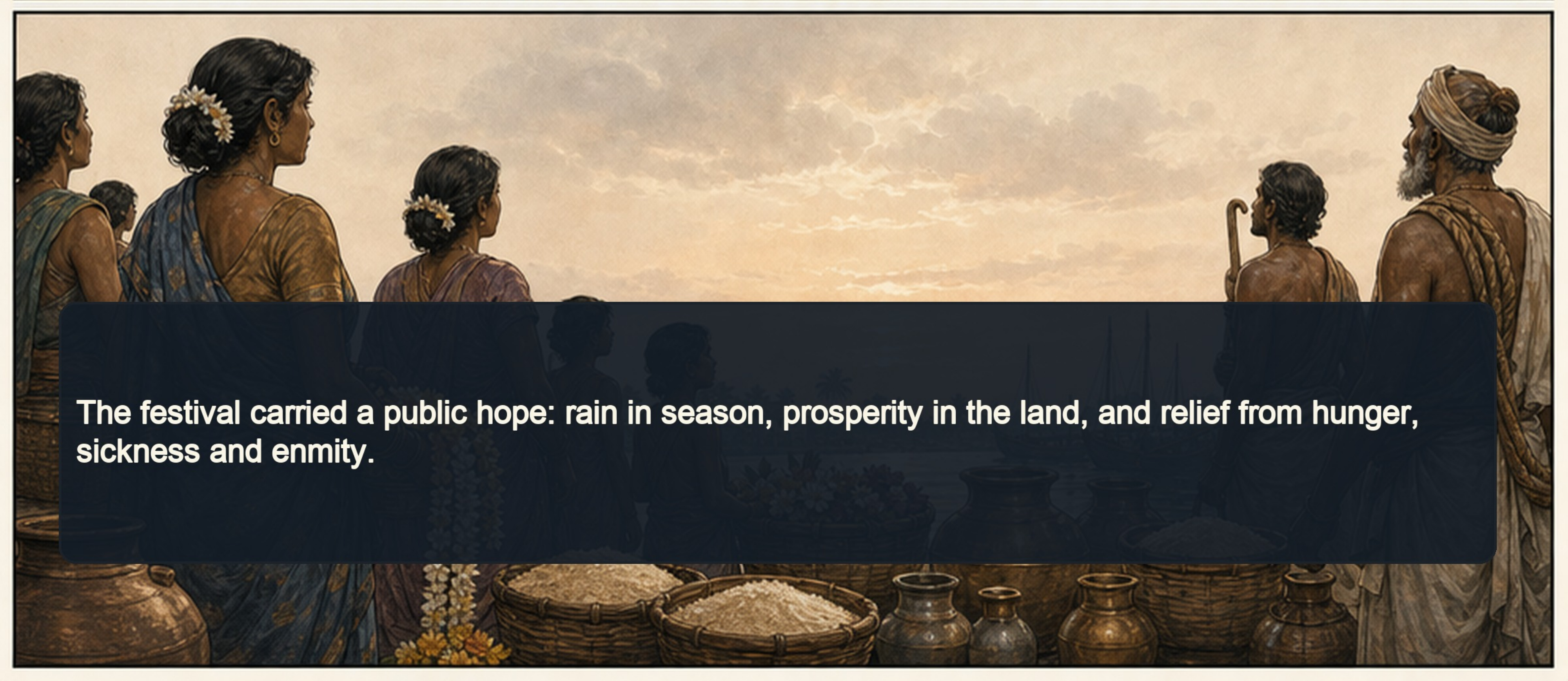


A man with a white cloth draped over his shoulder is playing a large, round drum. He is standing on a wooden platform. In the background, there is a coastal village with palm trees and boats on the water. The sky is filled with birds.

THUM.

A group of people in traditional Indian attire are standing in a line. From left to right: a man with a white cloth draped over his shoulder, a woman in a blue sari holding a pot, a woman in a red sari holding a pot, a man in a white cloth draped over his shoulder playing a flute, a man in a white cloth draped over his shoulder holding a spear and a shield, and a woman in a purple sari holding a pot.

People of Puhar! For twenty-eight days,
the festival of Indra will be observed.

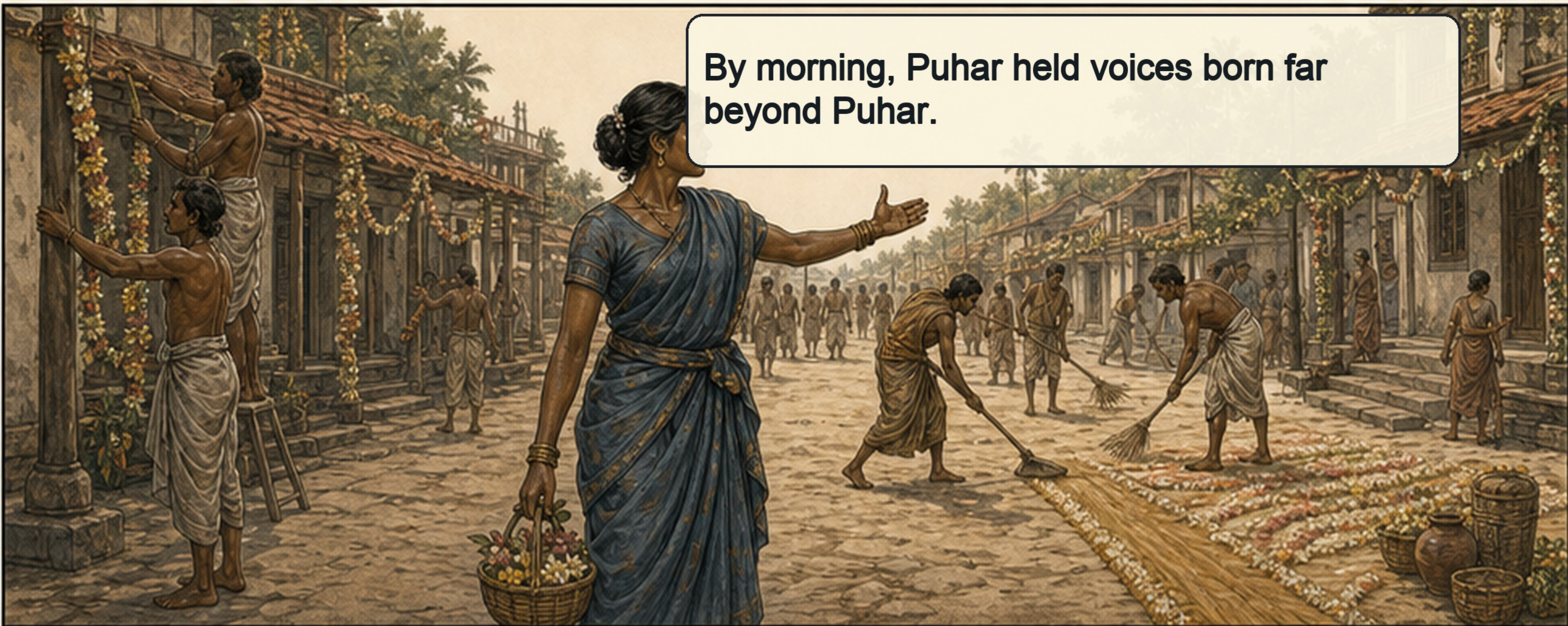
A group of people in traditional Indian attire are standing in a line. From left to right: a man with a white cloth draped over his shoulder, a woman in a blue sari holding a pot, a woman in a red sari holding a pot, a man in a white cloth draped over his shoulder playing a flute, a man in a white cloth draped over his shoulder holding a spear and a shield, and a woman in a purple sari holding a pot.

The festival carried a public hope: rain in season, prosperity in the land, and relief from hunger,
sickness and enmity.

Ships, roads and river craft brought strangers into the same streets.



By morning, Puhar held voices born far beyond Puhar.



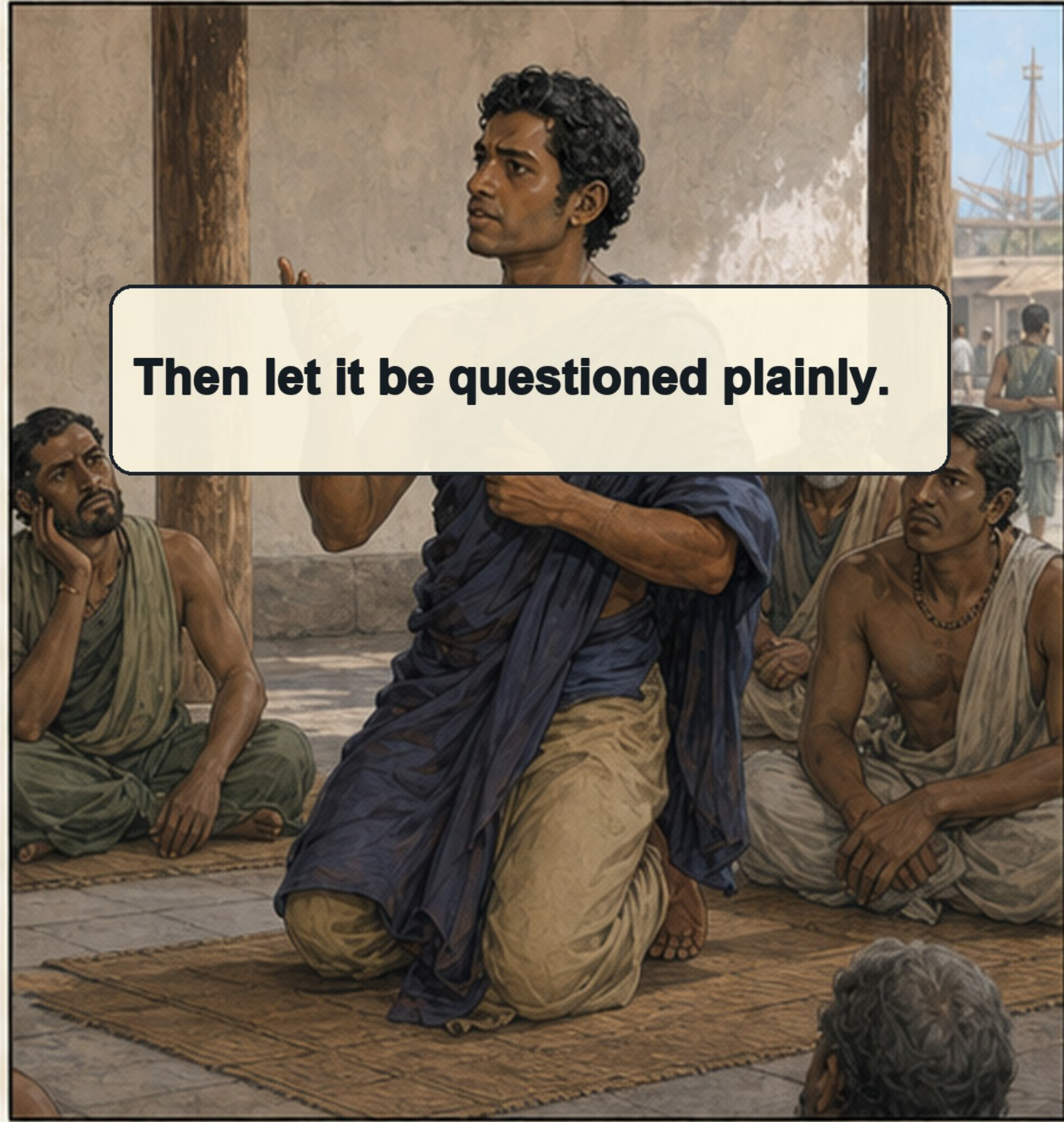
Teachers of different paths were called to speak.



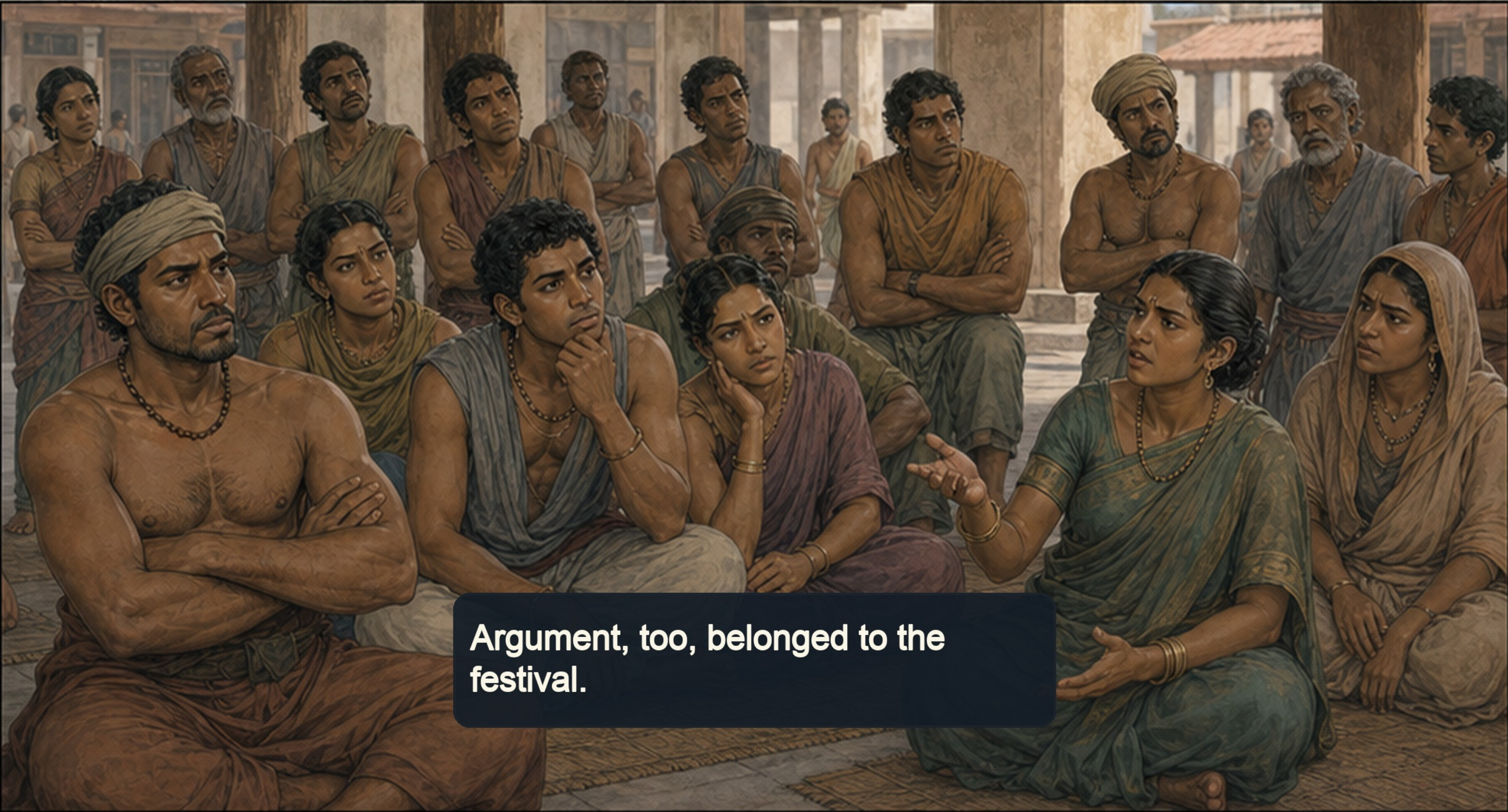
Let each teaching be heard plainly.



Then let it be questioned plainly.



Argument, too, belonged to the festival.



The drum promised abundance.



Abundance is tested in smaller measures.

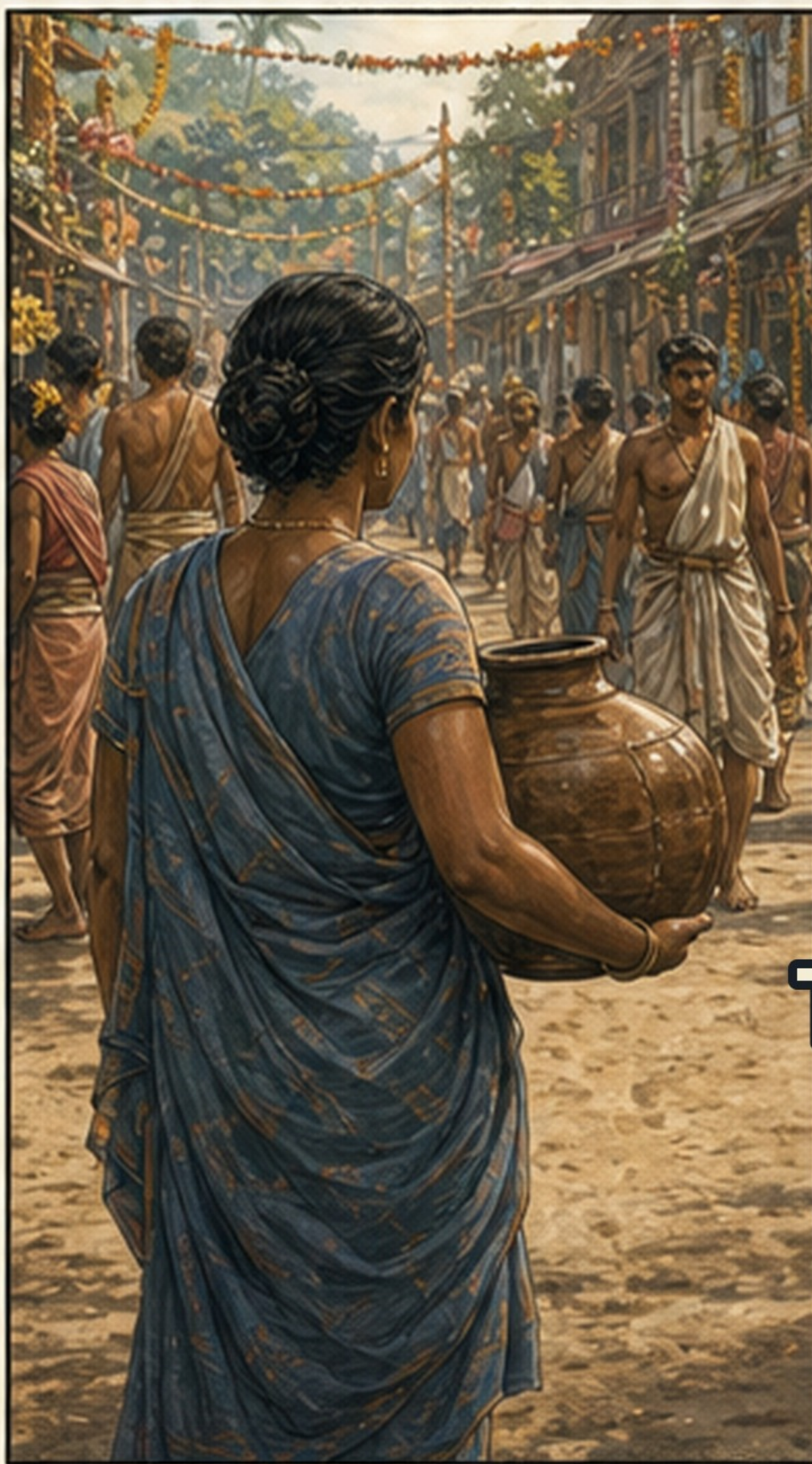


Grain. Water. Work. A place in the street.



By sunrise, work had become colour,
music, fragrance and order.

Puhar called it festival.

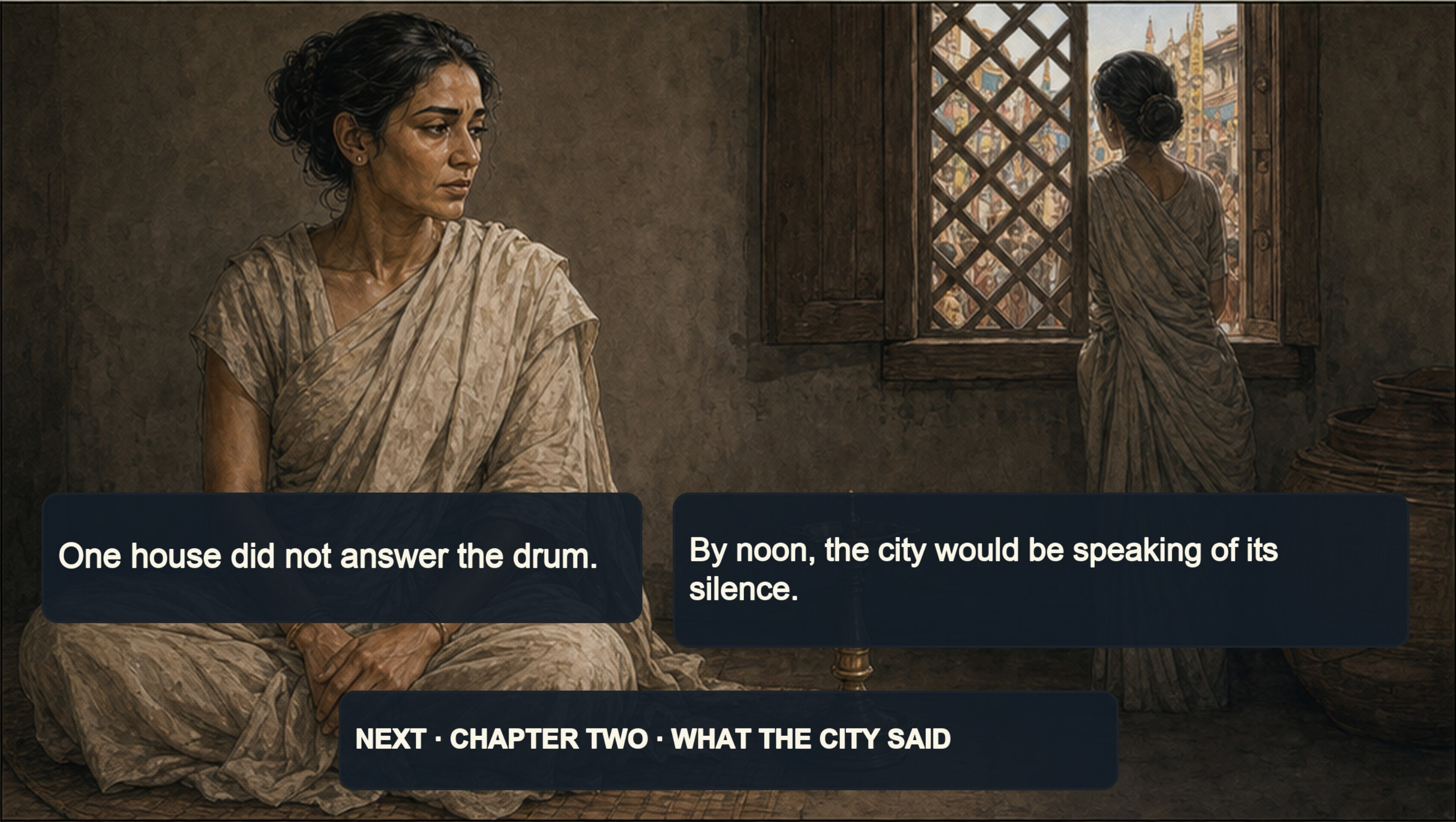




The festival begins!



THUM... THUM...



One house did not answer the drum.

By noon, the city would be speaking of its silence.

NEXT · CHAPTER TWO · WHAT THE CITY SAID